

SENATE RESOLUTION 343

By Walley

A RESOLUTION to honor University of Memphis basketball legend Nathaniel Root.

WHEREAS, on January 14, 2026, the University of Memphis (UM) welcomed home one of the most beloved and inspiring players in the history of Tigers' men's basketball, Nathaniel Root; and

WHEREAS, UM prevailed over Temple on that special day, and McNairy County native Nathaniel Root was honored by the university, a gesture that symbolized the unbreakable bond between the men's basketball program and one of its own; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Root was a fan favorite during his playing days, and when he was introduced in the FedEx Forum, the crowd erupted, with many fans chanting his name; and

WHEREAS, this touching moment served as a reminder that the impact of college athletics is not measured solely by points scored but also by character shown and inspiration left behind as a legacy; and

WHEREAS, this special night also reflected Mr. Root's lasting relationship with the UM community and his deep connection with the program; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Root graduated from high school without a single athletic scholarship offer; he enrolled at the University of Memphis in the fall of 1999 to pursue his lifelong dream of playing college basketball; and

WHEREAS, he walked on at UM, pursuing a roster spot with grit and persistence and finally earning his place on the team through relentless work and sacrifice; and

WHEREAS, Nathaniel Root's unrelenting effort and huge heart not only earned him the respect of Coach John Calipari and his teammates in the locker room but also the admiration of the Memphis faithful over time; and

WHEREAS, now an author, motivational speaker, and entrepreneur, Mr. Root continues to give back to the community through speaking engagements across the region, always encouraging students and young athletes to pursue their dreams with courage and resilience; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Root recently authored *Root: A Memphis Hoops Dream*, which features a foreword by Coach Calipari; the book chronicles his unlikely path from small-town McNairy County to the bright lights of Memphis and a major college basketball program; and

WHEREAS, resonating with athletes, coaches, and readers far beyond Memphis, Nathaniel Root's memoir captures behind-the-scenes moments from his playing career and recounts the emotional highs and lows that shaped him both on and off the court; and

WHEREAS, Nathaniel Root may no longer wear the Tiger Blue, but his legacy, heart, and story continue to echo throughout the UM men's basketball program, inspiring the next generation to dream big and work hard; and

WHEREAS, an icon whose past, present, and future is deeply woven into the fabric of Tiger basketball, Mr. Root is most worthy of our approbation; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, that we honor Nathaniel Root, author, motivational speaker, entrepreneur, and University of Memphis basketball legend, and extend to him our best wishes for much continued success and happiness.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy.